

great characters and good music.” Soon, word spread, and the last onion peel, he adds, was Akshaye Khanna’s performance. Deshpande says the treatment they had in mind was for it to be a “gangster film.” The sequel to *Dhurandhar* will be released this March.

The movie has done well beyond what Dutta or anyone else from the industry expected. “The audience now attaches a lot of importance to the story and not just stars. There is no doubt that a big star will give you an opening, but it’s really word of mouth after that,” he feels. He estimates that about 8% of viewers returned for a second showing, versus the usual 1–2%. “It offered a lot more to grasp, as a wholesome product, delivering on music, dialogues, and cast,” he adds. In fact, the second week surpassed the first at the box office. “There was a lot more to grasp since it was a wholesome product. It delivered on key factors like music, dialogues and star cast.” In fact, it made more in the second week at the box office than in the first.

REFINING THE MODEL

Bollywood’s cost structure has long been unstable, not very different from Telugu or Tamil markets, which also suffered from high star fees limiting success. Gowda is clear that money should not be spent on the stars. “Instead, it should go into the story, content and putting together a great narrative,” he says.

Take the case of *Mahavatar Narsimha*, a story that is not new by any stretch. Gowda says it goes back 40–50 years, with earlier versions released in Telugu and Kannada. “There is a large audience for devotional films, and we decided to focus on that. The trick in mythology is to keep it simple.”

In a post-pandemic world with OTT’s massive content offerings, audiences are more aware, discern-



“Today, the audience wants a big spectacle. Having a film with big stars has failed too often. (We have) consciously moved away (from that construct) and will sign on a star if there is a requirement”

JYOTI DESHPANDE
PRESIDENT, JIO STUDIOS



“It’s not as if we wanted to make a historical film (*Chhaava*). But we were clear that it had to be honourable content with wide appeal”

DINESH VIJAN
FOUNDER, MADDOCK FILMS

ing, and demanding, expecting new stories constantly.

Looking ahead, Maddock’s Vijan is clear that this year will see unique disruptors. “I expect 2027–28 to be a curveball as AI starts to affect content creators. We must learn to be screen agnostic in the face of technology,” he says. To Gowda, the requirement from the audience is simple. “They just want a good story, and that has never changed. The moment you do that, the audience will reward you,” he explains. *Border 2*, which released on January 23, is Bollywood’s first major success of 2026.

Studios are also increasingly looking at data on audience preferences, release windows, and digital engagement. They combine traditional instincts with modern analytics to make films more resistant to market changes.

Clearly, the industry is changing. Old formulas have become outdated, and new models, which are leaner, smarter, and driven by content, are gaining ground. However, AI presents a new challenge. It could make creation more accessible while increasing competition. This means studios need to rethink not just budgets and casting, but also their approach to intellectual property, creative processes, and audience engagement. The next decade will likely be shaped by how quickly Bollywood responds to this technological shift.

In a year of failures, a few films stood out. They showed that success is no longer about size, stars, or safe formulas. With stricter cost control, smarter risk-taking, and improved attention to audience preferences, the Hindi film industry is slowly finding a new direction. This new approach may determine its resilience in an AI-driven future. **BT**

@krishnagopalan